

2b. Content of GCSE (9–1) History A (Explaining the Modern World) (J410)

Learners will be required to study history:

- from three eras: Medieval (500–1500), Early Modern (1450–1750) and Modern (1700–present day);
- on three timescales: short (depth study), medium (period study) and long (thematic study); and
- in three geographical contexts: a locality (the historic environment), British, and European and/or wider world settings.

This means that learners will be required to study five different topics:

- 1 x thematic study;
- 1 x British depth study;
- 1 x non-British depth study;
- 1 x period study; and
- 1 x study of the historic environment.

The Specification Creator tool on the OCR website is a quick and easy way of checking that the topics you have chosen create a valid course of study. It is also a valuable mechanism for pointing centres towards appropriate support and building communities of centres teaching the same options. Use the Specification Creator tool before learners begin to study the course in order to ensure that a valid course of study is being followed.

Ensuring course coherence

Other than the linking of thematic study, British depth study, and the study of the historic environment, centres have free choice over how to combine topics in order to maximise the potential to exploit interest, expertise and resources. Coherence can be achieved in many ways, but is guaranteed by the nature of the different topics, the different emphases and

approaches which collectively engender an understanding of the nature of how historians work:

- in the period study, study focuses on a substantial and coherent medium time span of at least 50 years and requires learners to understand the unfolding narrative of substantial developments and issues associated with the period. The assessment will focus on the study of interpretations, alongside knowledge, understanding, explanation and analysis.
- in the non-British depth study, study focuses on a substantial and coherent short time span and require students to understand the complexity of a society or historical situation and the interplay of different aspects within it. The assessment will focus on knowledge, understanding, explanation and analysis, alongside the study of sources.
- in the thematic study, study focuses on understanding change and continuity across a long sweep of British history, including the most significant characteristics of different ages. The assessment will focus on knowledge, understanding, explanation and analysis.
- in the British depth study, study focuses on a substantial and coherent short time span and requires students to understand the complexity of a society or historical situation and the interplay of different aspects within it. The assessment will focus on knowledge, understanding, explanation and analysis, alongside the study of sources.
- in the study of the historic environment, study will examine the relationship between a place and historical events and developments. The assessment will focus on the study of sources, alongside knowledge, understanding, explanation and analysis.

All topic combinations result in a course that will ground and expand on learners' understanding of the world around us today.